



THE ROAD
TEMPLATES & WORKBOOKS



Scan the code for more workbooks

Talking To Your Kids About Your Case

Honest, age-appropriate words for one of the hardest conversations.

Your children know something is wrong. Children almost always sense more than adults think, and what they imagine is usually worse than the truth. The goal of this conversation is not to explain the law. It is to make your child feel safe, told the truth in a form they can hold, and certain they are still loved and not to blame.

You do not have to do this perfectly. You only have to do it with honesty and warmth. This guide gives you the shape of it and words you can borrow.

Four things to decide before you talk

- How much detail fits this child's age. A five-year-old needs reassurance. A fifteen-year-old needs honesty and respect.
- What is true but sayable. You can be honest without frightening them. Choose the true words a child can carry.
- Who else they trust. Name the adults who will be there, so they know the circle of care is bigger than just you.
- What they might overhear. A child who hears it from a whisper or a screen is hurt far worse than one you told.

The three things every child needs to hear

- This is not your fault. Children blame themselves for adult troubles. Say it plainly and more than once.
- You are safe and you will be cared for. Name who, where, and how, in concrete terms a child can picture.
- I love you, and that does not change no matter what happens to me.

Words you can borrow, by age

Young child (roughly 3 to 6):

“I made a mistake and some grown-ups who make the rules are upset about it. I might have to go away for a while to sort it out. It is not because of anything you did. You are safe, Grandma is going to be here, and I love you every single day, even when I am not next to you.”

Older child (roughly 7 to 12):

“I want to tell you what is happening myself, so you do not have to wonder or hear it from someone else. I am accused of breaking a law. A judge will decide what happens. It might mean I have to be away for a time. None of this is your fault, and it does not change how much I love you. You can ask me anything.”

Teenager (roughly 13 and up):

“I owe you honesty. Here is what is happening and what I know so far. I do not have every answer yet, and I will tell you what I learn as I learn it. You might hear things from other people or online. Come to me and I will tell you the truth. I am still your parent, I still love you, and none of this is on you.”

Questions they may ask, and how to hold them

- Are you a bad person? People can make mistakes and still be good and still love you. Being accused is not the same as being who you are.
- Are you going away? Answer honestly at their level. If you do not know, say so, and say who will care for them either way.
- Do not leave me. This is fear, not a question. Meet it with presence: who will be there, when you will talk, how you stay connected.

After the conversation

- ☐ Tell the other trusted adults what you told the child, so everyone tells the same true story.
- ☐ Give the child a concrete next contact: a call time, a visit, a letter.
- ☐ Watch for changes at school or in sleep. Loop in a counselor or teacher you trust. Keep the door open; this is many small talks, not one.

Sources and further reading: Sesame Workshop, “Little Children, Big Challenges: Incarceration” (sesamestreet.org/incarceration), a free research-based resource for families.

This workbook is educational and reflects lived and professional experience. It is not legal advice and does not create an attorney-client relationship. Laws and procedures vary by jurisdiction and change over time. For advice about your situation, consult a licensed attorney in your state.

More free tools and guidance: hub.newphysician.org/templates · bustedbythefed.com · whitecollaracademy.com

The Road · Templates & Workbooks